relationship together, and most of that was bad. Our greatest asset prior to becoming Christians was that we had no other place to go, so we stuck it out together. Only when we came to know Christ did we begin to realize that God's Word has basic principles governing every aspect of a marriage, including finances.

One of the first things I realized as I began to read God's Word was the contrast between what the Bible taught about money and what I had been taught in business school. The primary principle taught throughout most business schools is called OPM. It means Other People's Money. In our economy today it might also be described as the credit mentality—the ability to borrow that allows people to buy things they cannot afford to own. That principle works great in good times. Early in a marriage, it will allow you to accumulate a lot of things you otherwise couldn't afford. Unfortunately, later you'll have a real problem with that philosophy.

The classic example of that in our society today can be seen in the plight of America's farmers. Many young farmers came out of agricultural schools that taught OPM. They inherited farms that were debt-free and profitable. But with ever-appreciating land values, they were convinced that it was old-fashioned and foolish to sit on a farm with all that equity in it.

So initially they borrowed to upgrade the operation: better planters, better tractors, barns, silos. Every farming magazine carried glowing articles on the progressive farmers who turned idle equity into operating capital. Then the borrowing expanded to buy more land, which increased in value and could, in turn, be leveraged. Borrowed capital funded new homes, air-conditioned harvesters, new trucks, vacations. Farmers were on a roll. Eventually, the debts got so large that farmers borrowed to make interest payments, and so little cash was left over at the end of a season that they had to borrow to buy seed for the next. At this point they knew they were in trouble, but they were trapped by the very debt they had used to build too quickly.

Ultimately, the crisis came. Farm produce prices dropped